

Emperor

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Abstract

Empereur is an evocative and interactive virtual reality narrative that immerses users in the inner world of a father suffering from aphasia, a condition that severely impairs verbal communication. The story is told from the perspective of his daughter, who seeks to reconnect with him by piecing together his fragmented language and memories. Through hand-tracked interactions, users are invited to participate in the father's attempts to communicate, creating a narrative experience that transcends traditional storytelling formats.

Virtual reality plays a crucial role in enabling a fully immersive exploration of memory and language, offering a level of engagement that other formats cannot achieve. The experience is heightened by its poetic, black-and-white aesthetic and innovative hand-tracking system, which fosters a deep emotional connection between the user and the characters.

This essay explores the interactive elements and design choices that make Empereur a pioneering achievement in immersive storytelling. It also examines how the project leverages VR's unique capabilities to evoke empathy and engage audiences on a deeper emotional level, contributing significantly to the field of interactive media.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → Human computer interaction (HCI); Interaction paradigms; Virtual Reality; • **Applied computing** → Education; Interactive learning environments; • **Information systems** → Information systems applications; Multimedia information systems; Multimedia content creation.

Keywords

Documentary, Poetic, Aphasia

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1 EXPERIENCE OVERVIEW/INTRODUCTION

Empereur takes users on an emotional journey through the mind of a father who has lost his ability to speak due to aphasia. The story is told from the perspective of his daughter, who is attempting to

reconnect with him by piecing together fragments of his language and memories.

The VR experience begins with users seated, solving word puzzles that represent the father's attempts to communicate. As users progress, they transition to a standing position, exploring the father's memories in an open, dreamlike environment. Each interaction reveals a deeper layer of the father's life, allowing users to connect with him beyond the limits of verbal language. The narrative explores themes of memory, communication, and human connection in a deeply personal and universally relatable way.

2 FIGURES AND VISUAL ELEMENTS

Emperor aims to transcend traditional storytelling by leveraging virtual reality to offer profound insight into the impact of aphasia. The strategic implementation of VR dissolves barriers between the audience and the narrative, creating a deeply felt experience rather than one that is merely observed.

2.1 Key Goals

2.1.1 Innovative Storytelling. Fusing interactive elements with storytelling to enhance user engagement and emotional connection, maintaining a balance that reflects the protagonist's limited communicative capacity.

2.1.2 Artistic and Emotional Exploration. Pushing artistic boundaries with a minimalist aesthetic that heightens the sensory experience and makes each interaction meaningful.

2.1.3 Educational Impact. Educating audiences about aphasia's psychological and emotional dimensions through a personal and



Figure 1: Experience scenes

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Figure 2: Experience scenes

reflective narrative, utilizing VR to create a palpable sense of the condition's impact.

The selective use of hand-tracking technology and minimal but potent interactivity are designed to mirror the protagonist's communication struggles, fostering a strong empathetic connection.



Figure 3: Write with your finger

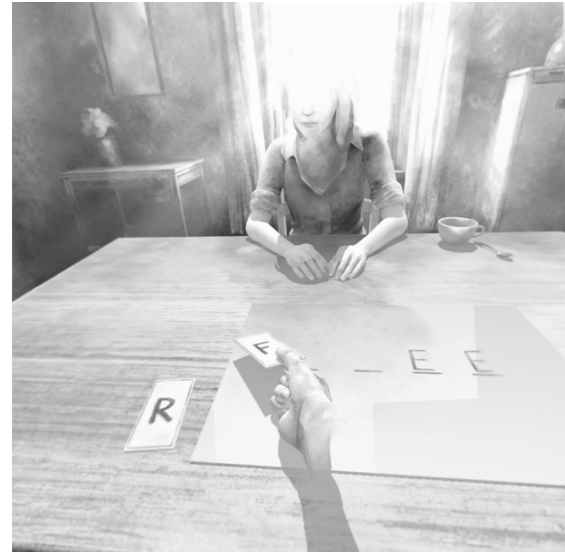


Figure 4: Make a word with cards

2.1.4 Awards and Recognition. Empereur has garnered widespread recognition, including: Venice Immersive: Achievement Prize SXSW Film & TV Festival: XR Experience Audience Award Stereopsia EUROPE: Best UX Design Experience XRMust Awards: Best Visual Experience Notable Selections: Annecy Film Festival, Luxembourg City Film Festival, Festival De Cannes, Prix Numix.

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Written and directed by: Marion Burger, Ilan J. Cohen Narration by: Olivia Cooke (English voice), Vimala Pons (French voice) Music by: Jamie Turner (Heran Soun) & Gaspar Claus Lead Producer: Oriane Hurard (Atlas V) Co-Producers: Katharina Weser (Reynard Films) Jeanne Marchalot (France Télévisions) A co-production of: Atlas V (France), Reynard Films (Germany), France Télévisions Supported by: CNC, FFF Bayern, Région Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes, MEDIA Creative Europe, Medienboard Berlin-Brandenburg, Bourse Beaumarchais Orange XR, Région Sud, Procirep-Angoa, Fondation Audiens Générations, SLM, Pico, Astrea.